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Travel Radio Australia, we're at the Disaster and Emergency Management Conference on the Gold Coast and I'm with a very interesting guy called Timothy Webb from SOTA International. Now, Timothy has a very extensive military background both in the military and in the medical field and SOTA International is a fascinating company. Tim, welcome to the program.

Geoff, thank you very much for having me. First of all, can you give us a bit about your background in these areas and how it pertains to this conference? Yeah, absolutely. My military service started back in 1998 in December where I joined as an Army Reservist and I was fortunate enough to serve in a Special Forces unit based in Melbourne, First Commando Regiment, which afforded me some great training.

I had a great love for what I was doing and in a few years' time decided to take that pursuit full-time. It was around this turn of the century that 4RL Commando, the East-based Special Forces unit, was raised in a full-time capacity as part of that East Coast counter-terrorism capability. Again, I've gone into a highly capable but young building unit.

Even in those early days, I got to attend various types of warfighting courses and demolitions but one was the combat medic course. Fast forward a few years, I did a deployment to Iraq with 4RL Commando in 2003 and then I chose to try out for SAS selection in 2004 and I was selected after attempting and completing the three-week selection course and then went on to conduct another 14-odd months of reinforcement training to bring me up to speed to be able to work in a SAS squadron. From there, I mean, I had an extremely busy career.

As you can imagine at that time, my first deployment immediately after my reinforcement cycle was to Afghanistan when the Australian forces returned for Rotation 1 of the Special Operations Task Group in 2005, again in 2008 on Rotation 6. And between those two deployments to Afghanistan, I went to East Timor twice in 2005 and 2006 on some shorter rotations, then had acquired a year or two before eventually departing defence on some long service leave in 2011 and to discharge in 2012 from the full-time army. I did remain in a part-time capacity at Special Air Service for about three more years. When I was leaving defence, I really looked at some of the skills that I was afforded by some world-class and now globally recognised accredited training from the US Department of Defence in what was and is tactical combat casualty care.

So I went into the industrial medic space in the mining industry in WA and did that for a number of years whilst earning a paramedic degree. And from there, realising that I probably wasn't going to get some of the clinical experience that I really was seeking to further that career in that industry, decided to move into the workplace health and safety and occupational health and safety realm in both mining and then eventually oil and gas. So that's really where the passion for what I'm doing now came from, which is forward medical care, predominantly at point of injury to try and benefit people that work in those high-risk and dangerous environments.

Worked in the workplace health and safety side as a safety advisor for the world's largest oil and gas company, publicly owned that is, and it was in 2020 with various lockdowns and being kept out of international travel for that company that I decided to form Sotra International. You know, for various reasons we've created a not-for-profit charitable company, deductible goods recipient status. The purpose behind this is we really are trying to make training, equipment and services as affordable to all of those that need it around Australia.

When forming the company, I needed to come up with a mission statement that was obviously broad enough that allowed us to have an evergreen approach to the current issues facing medicine in Australia. Our strategic mission statement is to strategically develop and position immediate medical and retrieval services in austere and remote environments to prevent the losses from trauma. And the entire purpose around that focusing on trauma is I was afforded the best training by the military and, you know, essentially the US military through this program that we were informally taking up within the Australian Special Air Service.

I just felt the need that I could give this back to society where our current first standards and courses weren't meeting, I guess, some of the industries that required slightly higher training. And essentially trying to start a training company in 2020, as you can imagine, became very difficult and we had face-to-face training issues and the like. So we quickly pivoted and we started providing paramedical services and we've naturally sort of moved into some equipment provision and sales as well across that time.

So once doors opened again in around 2022, we got fully accredited in our training model under the the US-based National Association of EMTs, which are globally recognised for their pre-hospital trauma life support range of courses. We now specialise in tactical emergency casualty care. Why that's important is, and it ties into why we're here as the platinum sponsor, is we've delivered a keynote speech this morning that has highlighted that the Australian first aid standard, whilst a great product and has done immense things for the Australian public over the last 20 or 30 years, has been created for low-risk and general first-aid type incidents and it's not fit for purpose for high-risk industry and especially emergency services.

And our immediate, I guess, task was always to try to provide a national standard for emergency responders, be they paid or volunteer, to create that single sheet of music and common language that they can all work off for the traumatic events that they see. It's a tremendous program that you've put together here and you work with groups like the SES and the police services and all over Australia and you were showing me some of your fantastic little products that you have here and you have a mini first aid kit here that actually has absolutely everything in there which virtually fits in your pocket that really for a first aid responder is fantastic. Yeah look and again this isn't anything new and definitely not attributed to me.

These are the concepts that came out of the military training and these individual first aid kits or immediate first aid kits are very small pouches designed to carry the four or five items that can

address the five most common causes of death from trauma. And one of the sayings that I like to throw out there and I did mention it in the keynote is trauma is agnostic. Your body doesn't know if it's a ballistic trauma or a penetration from some other metal projectile from an industrial accident.

What's happening inside your body is going to be exactly the same. You're going to have the same hole in your chest. You're going to have the same bleeding from vessels being disrupted.

These few items are highly critical for dealing with fairly decent trauma. Again it doesn't matter if that's a motor vehicle collision which still is our highest statistical issue for trauma here in Australia considering the geographic dispersion of how large our country is. Some of the places in rural communities you know it could be the person driving by.

It could be the local SES crew that gets called to it and by the time they get there chances are these patients may need these interventions. It's a fantastic program and what's you been your experience here at the at the event the disaster and emergency management conference. It's been a fantastic event for a lot of people.

Yeah look it's actually been really good. It's made me a little envious that for the last two years I've wanted to come down and exhibit and I've been a little slow and missed the the invitations to to apply and being committed to other exhibitions but we've had a really really good reception here. I think it's a fantastic conference that brings together the the full spectrum of emergency services and emergency management organisations.

Everything from your first responders both volunteer and paid, surf life-saving through to police. It also includes local councils and that's that's critical as especially here in Queensland we move towards 2032 Olympics that are going to be you know spread out across the Queensland state. Each of these councils also has as their own organisation stakeholders in emergency management for a what is going to be a global event and it's really critical again that we show that our emergency response is equal to global best practices and ultimately that's why we're here to spread that message that there's there's a lot of work to do in in the next six years.

Given that the right people are listening and ready to to make these these changes to better develop our first aid for first responders we're going to be very well prepared. Great Timothy Webb how can people find out more about SOTA International online? So you can head to our website SOTAinternational.com that's S-O-T-E-R International and additionally we're on Instagram and Facebook or LinkedIn for those on the the more of the professional side. You can see everything from just our local content doing training or product releases which we're often doing step changes in in equipment that may be smaller more cost efficient create a new capacity such as some of the products that we have in our blood type and testing range and blood transfusion range that we are putting through regulations at the moment and all of these are to again provide options to rural and remote communities they may not have normally available

through the lack of infrastructure out in those those areas so when it comes to an emergency situation there are products that potentially can be used.

Thanks so much Timothy it's been great speaking to you and thank you very much for your service in Australian military and thanks very much for the products that you have here for the Australian people. Really appreciate it thanks so much Geoff.